

Context Is Key

An Operational Reflection on Context and Understanding

One of the most common mistakes people make is assuming that information has meaning by itself.

It doesn't.

Information only has meaning within context.

Remove the context, and even true information can become misleading.

This problem appears everywhere.

A person misses a deadline.

Without context, they appear irresponsible.

With context, you discover they were covering for three absent teammates while handling an emergency project.

The same fact now tells a different story.

The behavior did not change.

The context did.

Organizations make this mistake constantly.

A metric increases.

A budget decreases.

An employee leaves.

A project slips.

Leaders rush to explain the event before understanding the environment surrounding it.

The result is often a perfectly logical conclusion built upon an incomplete understanding of reality.

The problem becomes even more dangerous in cybersecurity.

A failed login attempt might indicate an attacker.

Or it might indicate a user who forgot their password.

A large file transfer might indicate data exfiltration.

Or it might indicate a scheduled backup process.

An unusual network connection might indicate malware.

Or it might indicate a newly deployed application.

The observable event remains the same.

The interpretation changes entirely based on context.

This is why experienced operators rarely trust isolated observations.

They seek relationships.

Dependencies.

Timing.

Conditions.

Constraints.

History.

Environment.

The event itself is often the least interesting piece of information.

The surrounding circumstances usually explain far more.

This principle extends beyond technical systems.

People are systems.

Organizations are systems.

Governments are systems.

Families are systems.

Every system operates within a network of incentives, constraints, feedback loops, pressures, and dependencies.

When we ignore those factors, we begin treating symptoms as causes.

We mistake outcomes for intentions.

We confuse behavior with character.

We misunderstand success.

We misunderstand failure.

A manager sees declining productivity and assumes employees are disengaged.

An architect sees project delays and assumes the team is inefficient.

A leader sees resistance to change and assumes people are unwilling.

In many cases, the true cause is hidden somewhere else entirely.

The incentives may be wrong.

The priorities may conflict.

The resources may be insufficient.

The constraints may be overwhelming.

The observed behavior is merely the visible result.

The context is the explanation.

This is why systems thinking matters.

Systems thinking teaches us to look beyond the isolated event.

Instead of asking:

"What happened?"

It asks:

"What conditions made this outcome possible?"

That question changes everything.

It shifts focus away from blame and toward understanding.

Away from symptoms and toward causes.

Away from individual events and toward system behavior.

The best operators I have ever met shared a common trait.

They were relentlessly curious about context.

They rarely accepted simple explanations.

They rarely trusted first impressions.

They understood that reality is usually more complicated than the initial story suggests.

Not because they were cynical.

Because they were accurate.

The world is filled with facts.

Understanding comes from knowing how those facts connect.

Context provides those connections.

Without context, information becomes noise.

With context, information becomes understanding.

Context is not a supporting detail.

Context is the thing that gives every other detail meaning.

Tommy Burke is a cybersecurity engineer, systems thinker, author, and retired U.S. Army veteran exploring complexity, trust, authority, and the behavior of human, organizational, and technical systems.

“Asymmetric Precision”